

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Travel During Pregnancy

Safe travel planning for expectant mothers — air, car, and international tips

BEST TIME TO TRAVEL

The **second trimester (14–28 weeks)** is generally the safest and most comfortable time to travel. Morning sickness has usually resolved, energy is better, and the risk of miscarriage and preterm labor is lowest. Avoid non-essential travel after **36 weeks** — labor can occur unpredictably.

WHO SHOULD AVOID TRAVEL

- Preterm labor risk or history of preterm birth
- Placenta previa or placental abruption
- Uncontrolled hypertension or preeclampsia
- Incompetent cervix or cerclage
- Multiple pregnancy (especially after 28 weeks)
- Severe anemia
- Always get medical clearance before long trips

AIR TRAVEL

- ✓ Generally safe through 36 weeks for uncomplicated pregnancies
- Most airlines restrict travel after 36 weeks (some after 28 weeks for international)
- Get an aisle seat for easy bathroom access
- Walk every 1–2 hours to prevent blood clots
- Wear compression stockings (15–30 mmHg)
- Stay hydrated — aircraft air is very dry
- Radiation from cosmic rays at altitude is minimal for occasional flights

→ Bring a physician letter stating your due date for flights after 28 weeks — most airlines require it.

CAR TRAVEL

- Wear seatbelt correctly: lap belt **BELOW** the belly, shoulder belt between breasts and to the side of belly
- Stop every 1.5–2 hours to walk and stretch
- Avoid long trips in third trimester if possible
- Keep water and healthy snacks available
- Do not travel alone on very long trips
- Move seat back as far as comfortable from airbag

INTERNATIONAL TRAVEL CONSIDERATIONS

- Research medical care availability at your destination
- Check CDC travel health advisories before booking
- ✗ **AVOID** areas with Zika virus transmission
- ✗ **AVOID** areas with malaria (especially sub-Saharan Africa)
- Travel insurance with repatriation coverage essential
- Bring prenatal records and blood type card
- Know your Rh status and blood type

VACCINES & MEDICATIONS FOR TRAVEL

- ✓ **Safe:** Tdap, influenza (inactivated), hepatitis A/B, rabies
- ✗ **Avoid:** Live vaccines (typhoid oral, yellow fever, MMR, varicella)
- **Malaria prophylaxis:** Chloroquine/Atovaquone-proguanil generally safe **RX**
- ✗ Doxycycline for malaria — **AVOID** in pregnancy
- **DEET insect repellent** — safe when used as directed **OTC**
- Consult travel medicine clinic 4–6 weeks before departure

⚠ **SEEK MEDICAL ATTENTION WHILE TRAVELING IF**

- ⚠ Vaginal bleeding or fluid leaking
- ⚠ Severe abdominal pain
- ⚠ Signs of DVT: calf pain, redness, leg swelling
- ⚠ Decreased fetal movement
- ⚠ Regular uterine contractions or cramping
- ⚠ Severe headache, vision changes
- ⚠ High fever or illness
- ⚠ Sudden shortness of breath (PE)

♥ **With Good Planning, Travel Can Be Safe and Enjoyable**

Many pregnant women travel safely throughout their pregnancies. The key is choosing the right time, the right destination, and taking sensible precautions. Talk to your doctor before booking a significant trip — especially international travel — and enjoy your "babymoon" with confidence. Memories made now are precious!